NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠4

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠6

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥5

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 5 ♥ Q J 9 7 6 4 2 ♦ 9 ♣ K 9 4	
♠ A Q J 9 7 4 ♥ — ♦ K Q J 3 ♣ J 8 3	N W E S	♠ 10 2 ♥ K 8 3 ♦ 10 8 5 4 ♣ Q 10 6 2
	♠ K 6 3 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ A 7 6 2 ♣ A 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♠	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠10

You would really like to have a transfer bid in this situation, to make South bid ♥s.

But you don't have one, so you just bid 4♥ yourself.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠10. You play low in dummy and East holds the trick. He continues the suit and West takes the ♠Q and then plays the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

You've already lost the 2 ♠s. If East has the ♥K you might avoid a loser there. You don't have a winner on which to discard the ♣ loser.

If West has the ♥K it will have to be a singleton to help you, so it is more logical to play East for the ♥K. But if East does have the ♥K it will do you no good to ruff West's ♠A, East will over-ruff and you would still have that ♣ loser.

So do it this way instead. Discard the ♣ loser on West's ♠A! Another ♠ from West won't hurt you since dummy would be able to over-ruff East. Whatever West plays you can win, then finesse East out of his ♥K.

It was said earlier that you didn't have a winner on which you could discard the ♣ loser.

That was true, so instead you were able to discard it on a loser!

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 8 6 4 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ 10 7 3 ♣ Q J 3	
♠ 7 5 3 ♥ Q 3 ♦ K J 6 2 ♣ 8 5 4 2		♠ A Q J 10 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ A Q 8 5 ♣ K 10
	♠ 9 2 ♥ J 10 9 8 2 ♦ 9 4 ♣ A 9 7 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♥J

♠ K x x x ? Can you find a third entry to dummy?

With 20 HCP and balanced distribution you should open 2NT. Do not let the good 4-card ♠ suit sway you to anything else. Partner bids 3NT and everybody passes.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥J. You try the ♥Q, but North plays the ♥K.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more winners and at least 2 of them must come from ♠s. Furthermore you don't want North to lead ♣s through your King. Your best hope is that North holds the ♠K so you can finesse.

So you win the ♥A and start thinking about dummy entries. Your obvious entries are the ♦K and ♦J. If North holds only two small ♠s with his ♠K, then two entries will be enough. But what if North holds

If the ♦s split 3-2 the answer is **YES**. Play the ♦A, then lead your ♦8 to dummy's ♦J. Watch carefully to see if both defenders follow to this trick. They do. Play a ♠ to your ♠10, which holds the trick. Play your ♦Q to dummy's ♦K. Finesse the ♠ again. Return to dummy by playing your ♦5 to dummy's ♦6, then finesse the ♠ one last time.

If the ♦s had split 4-1 you would not have been able to enter dummy three times. That would have been very unlucky.

If you played your ♦5 too early you would not have been able to enter dummy three times even when there was a 3-2 split. That would have been very unsmart.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 3 ♥ J 8 3 ♦ 7 4 ♣ J 10 9 5 4	
♠ 10 8 5 4 2 ♥ Q 9 5 ♦ K 8 5 ♣ 8 3		♠ 7 6 ♥ K 10 7 ♦ Q J 6 2 ♣ Q 7 6 2
	♠ A Q 9 ♥ A 6 4 2 ♦ A 10 9 3 ♣ A K	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠4

You have 6 HCP and a 5-card suit. Although you can't be sure, there is a good chance your hand will be useful to partner.

So you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠4. You play dummy's ♠3 and East contributes the ♠6.

You can get them in ♣s, but only if you are careful.

After you unblock the ♣ A K you will go to dummy and play the ♣J. Then, after the ♣Q is driven out you will return to dummy for the two ♣ winners. That means you need **TWO** dummy entries.

Those two entries can only be the ♠K and ♠J. So you absolutely **MUST** win the first trick in your hand with the ♠A. Then play the ♣ A K. Over to dummy by playing ♠9 to ♠J. Lead the ♣J to drive out the ♣Q. Win whatever they return and play ♠Q to ♠K to reach your two good ♣s.

When you need dummy entries you may need to win a trick in your hand with an unnecessarily high card - like in this case.

You can only win 3 ♠ tricks however you play it, so you play to suit your entry needs.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K 10 8 6 2 ♥ Q 10 4 ♦ J 8 4 3 ♣ 6	
♠ A J 5 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ A K 6 ♣ J 10 9 2		♠ 7 4 ♥ K 7 5 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ A Q 8 4 3
	♠ Q 9 3 ♥ J 9 8 ♦ Q 10 7 2 ♣ K 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠6

With no 4-card Major suit you respond 2♦ to partner's Stayman bid. Partner now bids 2NT.

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With a full 17 points you accept partner's game invitation and bid 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠6 on which South plays the ♠Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more tricks, obviously coming from the ♣ suit.

But the burning question right now is what do you do at trick one. Do you win or hold up?

You should assume that North holds the ♠K.

If you take the ♠A right now your ♠ J 5 will provide a second stopper if it is North who gets the lead. However, if South gets the lead he will play through your holding and you may lose 4 ♠ tricks.

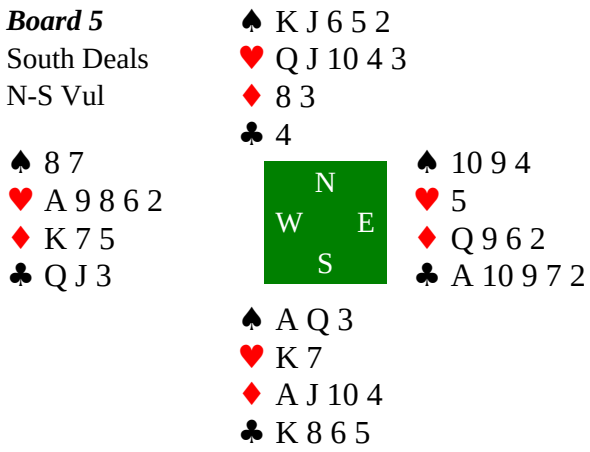
If you hold up you can expect South to play another ♠ through your ♠ A J and North will then establish the suit. However, in doing so he will remove any ♠ held by South.

The answer key lies in the ♣ suit. You will be finessing through North, so South is the only defender who can get the lead in ♣s. Therefore you must hold up on ♠s until the third round.

If you win the first ♠ South will play a ♠ through your ♠ J 5 when he wins the ♣K. North will then swamp you with ♠s.

But, if you hold up your ♠A until the third round, South will have no ♠ left when he wins the ♣K.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥5

When you are 5-5 in the Majors you can transfer to either suit. Most will say transfer first to ♥s when you have invitational strength. So you bid 2♦.

Partner says 2♥;

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Partner says 2♥;

Now you show your other 5-card Major by bidding 2♠. This one hits the spot and partner raises to 4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥5. West takes the ♥A and returns the ♥6 which East ruffs. East then plays the ♦2.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

That's an odd way to show the second ♥ loser but you get the idea. You've lost 2 tricks already and it doesn't look like you can dodge the ♣A. Soooooo, you cannot afford to lose a ♦ trick.

Take dummy's ♦A and then play ♠A, ♠K, relaxing a little when both defenders follow suit both times.

Play your three high ♥s, discarding all three ♦s from dummy. Play your ♣ toward the ♣K. East will no doubt grab his ♣A but the rest will be yours, since you can ruff your ♦ loser in dummy.

It was a little unlucky to suffer that early ♥ ruff.

But it was very very lucky that the ruffer happened to be the defender with three trumps!

That meant you could pull trumps with two pulls, leaving that one important one in dummy.